Bashir Gemayel, his brother Amin succeeded him as president and pledged to support our efforts to bring peace to the region. He was a modest, able young man devoted to ending the bloody strife that had torn apart his homeland. During a visit to Washington, he urged me to keep the marines in Lebanon while efforts continued to reach a settlement. I agreed.

Meanwhile, several leaders of the Jewish community in America endorsed the September 1 peace initiative, agreeing that it contained the possible seeds for a long-term solution to the Arab-Israeli conflict. Shimon Peres's opposition Labor Party in Israel also endorsed the plan, despite Begin's continuing resistance, and we continued to get positive, if qualified, signs of interest from Arab leaders.

In November, Phil Habib returned to Lebanon to attempt to get the stalled plan for simultaneous withdrawal of Syrian and Israeli forces back on track. He said the situation had deteriorated substantially since Bashir Gemayel's assassination. The Israelis were now adamantly against leaving Beirut because they feared the PLO might then return to Lebanon; the Arab leaders complained that the continuing presence of Israeli forces in Beirut threatened whatever chances our peace initiative had.

In early December, after I made a brief trip to Latin America, Habib and I had lunch in my study. He had made another trip to the Middle East and was very gloomy. He said that he thought the prospects of ending the bloody war in Lebanon were growing worse each day instead of better. As long as the Israelis refused to leave Beirut, he said, the Arabs would cite their refusal as proof that they didn't want peace, and that it was a waste of the Arabs' time to negotiate with Habib. The Middle East was so unpredictable and explosive, Habib said, that time was of the essence: It was essential to consummate the withdrawal of all foreign forces as quickly as possible or we'd lose a historic